

# Crime and Punishment: Critical Analysis

By Fyodor Dostoyevsky

*Who is to blame? The man or his surroundings? Does crime come before punishment or does punishment come prior to the crime, itself?*

In the whirlpool called life, our affluent regular narrative often goes unchallenged. Our normative thought processes shaped by those that win wars are made to be set in stone.

**Yet, somehow, somewhere, somebody silently approaches an alternative reality, a way forward, an almost encompassing determent.**

In this case, we find Fyodor Dostoyevsky providing a destitute channel of a multiverse excluding regularity and preconceived notions of reality.

Crime and Punishment (Dostoevsky) deliberates the lives of many through the eyes of one who seems to serve as the other in contrast to the many. The novel illustrates the inner dialogues and musings of a complex individual, Rodian Romanovitch Raskolnikov, during the 1800's. He is formed in light of the rebellion ideology that was developing after Tsar Alexander the second's regime. It is imperative to note that although his ideologies seemed deviant and treacherous then, are to this day, prevalent in many societies still, yet are not uncommon or new.

Many novels borrowing from Dostoyevsky's nihilistic approach, have been written and exemplified by developing and adding on to the initial narrative, in popular English and American plays and books, for example, The Stranger by Albert Camus. What is fascinating and integral to note are the similar yet substantially unique ways in which alienated individuals such as the stranger, himself in Camus' work and Rodian Raskolnikov meet their ends.

We also find a resolve that seems unrealistic yet hopeful in retrospect considering the gloomy and melancholic tone of the novel, itself. It ends with certified love and ownership of one's actual. An end which I personally do not entirely agree with and will unfold by the end of this essay. I sit on a metal fence that will remain till the end of a world whose two continually major ideologies remain in friction, those of capitalism and communism, further splitting into realism and idealism, nature and nurture.

**Who is to blame? The man or his surroundings? Does crime come before punishment or does punishment come prior to the crime, itself?**

This opens up the thematic setting of the book. I have chosen to focus mainly on its themes of alienation, causality, nihilism and the idea of punishment, itself. The novel untraditionally contemplates the ideas of repercussions, dissatisfaction, harmony and selfishness. What makes the novel for me enticing is its unconventional allegorized exhibit of human psychology, raw and unfiltered. It is through this, that the theme of selfishness can fully be embodied. Compared to American novels and popular culture films depicting the same

rhetoric, although portraying them in a darker sentiment and light, for example, American Psycho (Garner) and Psycho by Alfred Hitchcock (Brody) , and romanticizing the idea of murder.

Raskolnikov is the protagonist one does not expect one to aspire to be, unlike American murders. Why this is, illuminates the idea of the nihilistic nature from which the character exposes his inner workings. Violent in a very nonchalant manner, to an extent where the guilt of his murders consumes him. His nihilism then is not simply the typically abused case of nothing matters but a sort of meaninglessness that is still attached to the idea of consequence and physical punishment and moreover of remorse and acceptance.

Punishment then, becomes an ambiguous, open interpretation of one's own perception of it.

For Svidrigaïlov, punishment is a dirty room filled with complimenting crawling dirty animals, which is something Raskolnikov is already used to, and the thought of being given that as a permanent consequence to bare, seems nauseating. As the story moves further, we find in his end monologue, that Raskolnikov has come to enjoy his prison surroundings and that the idea of his doomed destiny is not as demonic and abhorrent as he conceived it to be, further revealing a key factor in the idea of punishment, itself, i.e. that of expectations vs. reality.

### **Is the fear of punishment grander than of the punishment itself? Perhaps.**

Raskolnikov mentions how his sickness in the end is a result of the other inmates attempts to murder him rather than prison life, itself. However, in this regard, one who deviates from societal norms or challenges the status quo, often is subjugated in the most violent of tortures. Take for example, the gruesome, soul shaking stories of Alcatraz and Riker's Island (Lee) amongst many others, whose main goal is to torture their inmates.

In the novel, Raskolnikov himself marks that the hospital is the only place he feels himself healing and even repenting to a certain degree. This brings to the stage, the notion of whether law enforcement and correctional facilities are actually places of correction or just torture cells. In The New Jim Crow (Alexander) explains the hidden inner workings of correctional facilities and reveals the opposite of correcting done by the state that leads to mass

incarceration and inmates to eventually fall back into the same prison trap after they are released.

### **This phenomenon vivifies the brutal strapped circumvent of alienation.**

Karl Marx symbolizes alienation as a process of othering or marginalizing an individual who lacks the conformity by which everyone else is clocking to (Marx) . It is therefore almost justifiable for Raskolnikov to have the end that he did, in a system that has set rules for every deviant action an individual decides to make — The book has been called a fantastic realistic novel (Essays), which then proceeds to claim the justification for its unrealistic end, that which is his seemingly validated achievement of finding love and therefore acceptance and remorse, seems far-fetched and unlikely. In this case, American Psycho and Psycho then seem more likely at being realistic as those characters also seemed to have a superior sense of themselves in order to commit the murders, the difference then lays in Raskolnikov's acceptance and confounding love for Sonya that turns him into any other

remorseful man, which Dostoyevsky, it seems has tried so hard throughout the novel to not deliver, at the end, and the other's to take it in stride and remain steadfast in their commitment to their ideologies. His unique alienation — enveloped in a larger systemic oppression, leads him to the murders.

In other words — **he is punished for being deviant long before he ever committed any crime, and then punished for acting the way, he was forced to act in the first place.**

Although, it further brings into light the notion that if such terrible circumstances existed for all, then how has anarchy and universal chaos not risen yet? It almost seems as though, by the end of all three stories, the society they were rebelling so hard against, in despicably was triumphant. Perhaps, only in the physical because the system has not yet infiltrated — the minds of deviants yet.

*Feasibly, then because many remain in the fear of the punishment and choose to think the same thoughts but never act on them. Fear and the shedding of it is what lingers on for me, after reading the book. Raskolnikov starts off as being fearless in order to commit the crime, fearful after the crime and reverberates back to a fearful, apologetic citizen by the end of the novel, returning back to love, which strips him off of his hatred of the world —*

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Book Review